

Angles & Verticals

Building structure with straight lines

Angles are the skeleton of accurate drawing. By finding and transferring the angles of major edges and landmarks, you can build a structurally accurate drawing before adding any curves or detail.

KEY CONCEPTS

Sighting Angles

Hold your pencil at arm's length and align it with the angle you want to measure — a shoulder line, the edge of a jaw, the tilt of a torso. Keep your arm locked and transfer this angle to your paper.

Vertical Reference

Vertical is your most important reference. Everything in your drawing is either vertical, horizontal, or at an angle relative to those two axes. Check every major line: is it more vertical, more horizontal, or 45°?

Tilt & Counter-Tilt

In figure drawing, the body rarely stands perfectly vertical. The shoulders tilt one way; the hips counter-tilt the other. These angles create contrapposto — the natural weight-shift that makes figures feel alive.

Line of Action

The line of action is a single angle or curve that captures the dominant movement of a pose. Find it first. Everything else in the drawing supports this primary angle.

PRACTICE EXERCISES

1. Draw 5 poses using ONLY straight lines — no curves. Get the angles right first.
2. Practice sighting: hold pencil up, measure 10 different angles around the room.
3. Draw a figure, focusing only on the angles of the major bones (not the flesh).

FURTHER READING

■ Proko – Angles and Measuring

<https://youtu.be/C8XGCeIJzXE>

■ Vilppu – Line of Action

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=KBjRCu-YRKQ>